



Ages 14 to 18

Grooming: Spotting It and Getting Help

How grooming works online and offline, what the law says, what to do, and how to help a friend. For all students.

Before You Read This guide covers grooming for sexual abuse, exploitation and radicalisation.

This guide is about grooming: when someone builds a relationship with a young person in order to abuse, exploit or use them. It mentions sexual abuse, images and exploitation, without graphic detail. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains how grooming works, what the law says, what to do if something feels wrong, and how to help a friend.

- Grooming can happen online or offline, and the person can be a stranger or someone you know: an adult, or someone only a bit older.
- It works by feeling like a real, special relationship. **Clever, confident people get groomed too.**
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**, and you won't be in trouble for asking for help.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.
- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone has asked to **meet you**, is asking for **images**, or is threatening you, tell an adult straight away, or report to CEOP.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Grooming

Building someone's trust and a connection with them in order to get them to do something sexual or illegal, or to harm them.

Exploitation

Using someone for sex, crime, money or status, often in exchange for something they want or need, like gifts, attention or protection.

Radicalisation

Being drawn into supporting extremist views or groups, often through someone offering belonging or purpose.

Position of trust

Certain roles set out in law, such as school staff, and sports coaches or religious teachers who regularly coach or teach a young person. It is a crime for someone in one of these roles to have sexual contact with an under-18 they are responsible for.

How Grooming Works

- **Trust and attention:** "You're so mature." "I'm the only one who really gets you."
- **Gifts and favours:** money, game credit, vapes, lifts or clothes, which later become a debt: "After everything I've done for you..."
- **Secrecy and isolation:** "Don't tell your parents." Criticising your friends until you see them less.

- **Testing boundaries:** jokes or sexual talk that go a little further each time.
- **Moving out of sight:** from a game or group chat to a private app; asking for images; suggesting a meeting.

The same steps are used to draw young people into **sexual abuse**, **crime** (carrying things, holding money, recruiting others) or **extremist groups**. A pattern can help you see what is happening, but **you don't need to wait for it to happen again before asking for help**.



Healthy or Unsafe?

Healthy Relationships With Older People

- Open: you can talk about them with a trusted adult of your choice, at school, in boarding or outside your family
- Respect your age, your boundaries and your other relationships
- Gifts without strings; no pressure, no debts
- An adult in a professional role keeps professional boundaries

Warning Signs

- Secrets, and a "special" bond no one else can know about
- A big age or power gap, or someone who seems too good to be true
- Pressure for images, sex, meeting, or "favours"
- A teacher, coach or tutor messaging you privately outside agreed channels
- Being asked to bring friends along to meet them



What the Law Says

England and Wales

- It is a crime for an adult (18 or over) to send sexual messages to a child under 16, or to try to get them to send sexual messages (Sexual Offences Act 2003, section 15A).

- It is a crime for an adult who has been in contact with a child under 16 to meet them, or travel or arrange to meet them, intending to commit a sexual offence (section 15).
- Adults in a position of trust, such as school staff, and sports coaches or religious teachers who regularly coach or teach them (the law sets out which roles count), commit a crime if they have sexual contact with a young person under 18 in their care, **even if you are 16 or 17 and agree** (section 16; section 22A).
- Nude or sexual images of anyone under 18, including AI-made ones, are illegal to make, keep or share.
- If you're 16 or 17, grooming and exploitation are still abuse, even where the law on consent is different.
- The police and courts decide whether a crime has happened, not you. **If you're the one being targeted, you won't be in trouble for asking for help.**

What the Data Shows

7,263

offences of sexual communication with a child recorded by 44 UK police forces in a year

NSPCC, 2025

Almost 2x

the number recorded in 2017/18, when the offence came in

NSPCC, 2025

Most victims recorded were girls, but boys are targeted too. Recorded crime is only part of the picture. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- NSPCC, *Data shows how criminals are using private messaging platforms to manipulate and groom children* (13 November 2025)

If It's Happening to You

What to Do

- **Don't meet up** with someone you've only met online. If you've already agreed to meet, don't go. Tell a trusted adult now. You won't be in trouble.
- **Don't send images**, even if they send one first or it feels like part of a relationship.

- **Tell a trusted adult.** You won't be in trouble, whatever you've already sent or said.
- **Keep it.** Don't delete. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help. If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- Don't tell the person you've told someone; let adults decide what happens next.

If Images Have Been Shared or Someone Is Threatening You

- It is not your fault. Tell a trusted adult, or report to CEOP.
- **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.

It's Not Your Job to Investigate

- You don't have to prove anything, find out who someone really is, or collect evidence. That's for adults.

If Someone Asks You to Bring Friends

- Sometimes young people are asked to introduce friends to someone, or to recruit others for "jobs". That can be a sign you are being groomed or exploited too.
- You can stop, and you can tell. Adults will see you as someone who needs help, not as the problem.

RESPOND: If You're Worried About a Friend

Friends are often the first to notice. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps, Pause is the bridge, and adults lead the systems steps.**

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)



Recognise

Notice what's happening.

- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (a new older friend?), **Places** (where do they meet?), **Platforms** (a move to a private app?), **Patterns** (gifts, secrecy, dropping friends?)
- You don't need certainty to act



Engage

Reach out privately.

- "You've seemed different lately. I'm here if you want to talk." Don't attack the person they like: it can push your friend closer to them
- **If it is safe to do so**, the best options are to **Delegate** (tell a trusted adult), **Distract** (make plans together) and **Delay** (check in later). Don't confront the person yourself



Support

Stay close.

- Keep including them. Grooming works by cutting people off

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Think before you act.

- Three questions: **Risk** (is a meeting planned?), **Rights** (what does your friend need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- Don't contact the person, go through your friend's phone, or collect screenshots

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Show what a safe relationship looks like, and offer to go with them to an adult



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- Tell an adult, even if you promised not to. **A planned meeting or images: tell them straight away**



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Just tell them what you know



Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- Adults won't contact or confront the person without a plan to keep you safe. If you're worried about how your family will react, say so: the adult will think carefully about how, and whether, your family is told.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

Whoever You Are

- If the person is a member of staff, a coach or someone else you're meant to trust, you can still tell. Concerns about staff go to the headteacher, and there are people outside school who check how they are handled.
- LGBTQ+ young people looking for understanding online can be targeted by people offering it. You can talk to a trusted adult without being "outed". Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- If you have SEND, or find it hard to tell whether someone is being genuine, ask an adult you trust. That's a sensible thing to do, not a failure.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's a real relationship, so it's not grooming"	Grooming is designed to feel real. Secrets, gifts with strings and pressure are the warning signs.
"I'm 16, so it's my choice"	At 16 you can consent to sex, but it is a crime for someone in a position of trust over you to have sexual contact with you, and exploitation is abuse at any age.
"Only girls get groomed"	Boys are groomed too, for sex, crime or extremism.
"If I sent images, I'll be in trouble"	Young people who are targeted are treated as victims. Asking for help is the right move.

If You Board

- You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.

- If contact happens at night, or someone wants to meet you at the weekend or on an exeat, tell the house parent on duty straight away.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19)**: 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout**: text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency)**: ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse, or worries about the way someone has been communicating with a child online. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. In danger now? Call 999 first.
- **Emergency**: call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Grooming: Spotting It and Getting Help: Student Guide 31 - 14 to 18

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